Verified

Men's Ballon d'Or

France Football created the Ballon d'Or in 1956. Eligibility rules changed over time: the award was initially limited to European players, opened to players of any nationality at European clubs in 1995, and became fully global in 2007. From 2010 through 2015 it was presented jointly with FIFA.

Men's Ballon d'Or winners, 1956 to present

Year	Winner	National team	Ceremony date	Story
2026	**Harry Kane**	England	26 October 2026	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Harry Kane won the 2026 Ballon d'Or, England's first winner since Michael Owen claimed the award in 2001.
2025	**Ousmane Dembélé**	France	22 September 2025	—
2024	**Rodri**	Spain	28 October 2024	—
2023	**Lionel Messi**	Argentina	30 October 2023	—
2022	**Karim Benzema**	France	17 October 2022	—

Year	Winner	National team	Ceremony date	Story
2021	**Lionel Messi**	Argentina	29 November 2021	—
2020	**Not awarded**	—	—	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story The 2020 Ballon d'Or was the only edition since the award's creation in 1956 not to be presented.
2019	**Lionel Messi**	Argentina	2 December 2019	—
2018	**Luka Modrić**	Croatia	3 December 2018	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Luka Modrić became the only Croatian winner of the Ballon d'Or in 2018, the same year he also won the World Cup Golden Ball.
2017	**Cristiano Ronaldo**	Portugal	7 December 2017	—
2016	**Cristiano Ronaldo**	Portugal	12 December 2016	—
2015	**Lionel Messi**	Argentina	11 January 2016	—
2014	**Cristiano Ronaldo**	Portugal	12 January 2015	—
2013	**Cristiano Ronaldo**	Portugal	13 January 2014	—

Year	Winner	National team	Ceremony date	Story
2012	**Lionel Messi**	Argentina	7 January 2013	—
2011	**Lionel Messi**	Argentina	9 January 2012	—
2010	**Lionel Messi**	Argentina	10 January 2011	—
2009	**Lionel Messi**	Argentina	1 December 2009	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Lionel Messi won the first of his eight Ballon d'Or titles in 2009, more than any other player in the award's history.
2008	**Cristiano Ronaldo**	Portugal	2 December 2008	—
2007	**Kaká**	Brazil	2 December 2007	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Kaká won the 2007 Ballon d'Or, the first year the award was open to players at any club worldwide, not just clubs in Europe - eligibility had already widened to any nationality in 1995.

Year	Winner	National team	Ceremony date	Story
2006	**Fabio Cannavaro**	Italy	27 November 2006	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Fabio Cannavaro (Italy) won the 2006 Ballon d'Or the same year he captained Italy to the World Cup title.
2005	**Ronaldinho**	Brazil	28 November 2005	—
2004	**Andriy Shevchenko**	Ukraine	13 December 2004	—
2003	**Pavel Nedvěd**	Czech Republic	22 December 2003	—
2002	**Ronaldo**	Brazil	12 December 2002	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Ronaldo (Brazil) won the 2002 Ballon d'Or the same year he also won the World Cup and that tournament's Golden Boot.
2001	**Michael Owen**	England	18 December 2001	—
2000	**Luís Figo**	Portugal	19 December 2000	—
1999	**Rivaldo**	Brazil	21 December 1999	—

Year	Winner	National team	Ceremony date	Story
1998	**Zinedine Zidane**	France	22 December 1998	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Zinedine Zidane (France) won the 1998 Ballon d'Or the same year he also won the World Cup.
1997	**Ronaldo**	Brazil	23 December 1997	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Ronaldo (Brazil) is the Ballon d'Or's youngest-ever winner, aged 21 when he won in 1997.
1996	**Matthias Sammer**	Germany	24 December 1996	—
1995	**George Weah**	Liberia	26 December 1995	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story George Weah became the first African player to win the Ballon d'Or in 1995.
1994	**Hristo Stoichkov**	Bulgaria	20 December 1994	—
1993	**Roberto Baggio**	Italy	28 December 1993	—
1992	**Marco van Basten**	Netherlands	22 December 1992	—
1991	**Jean-Pierre Papin**	France	24 December 1991	—

Year	Winner	National team	Ceremony date	Story
1990	**Lothar Matthäus**	West Germany	25 December 1990	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Lothar Matthäus (West Germany) won the 1990 Ballon d'Or the same year he captained West Germany to the World Cup title.
1989	**Marco van Basten**	Netherlands	26 December 1989	—
1988	**Marco van Basten**	Netherlands	27 December 1988	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Marco van Basten (Netherlands) won the 1988 Ballon d'Or the same year he also won the EURO Golden Boot and the Netherlands won the title.
1987	**Ruud Gullit**	Netherlands	29 December 1987	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Ruud Gullit (Netherlands) won the 1987 Ballon d'Or the year before he captained the Netherlands to the EURO 1988 title.

Year	Winner	National team	Ceremony date	Story
1986	Igor Belanov	Soviet Union	30 December 1986	—
1985	Michel Platini	France	24 December 1985	—
1984	Michel Platini	France	25 December 1984	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Michel Platini (France) won the 1984 Ballon d'Or the same year he captained France to the EURO title and finished as the tournament's top scorer.
1983	Michel Platini	France	27 December 1983	—
1982	Paolo Rossi	Italy	28 December 1982	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Paolo Rossi became the only player in history to win the World Cup, its Golden Ball, its Golden Boot, and the Ballon d'Or all in the same year, 1982.
1981	Karl-Heinz Rummenigge	West Germany	29 December 1981	—
1980	Karl-Heinz Rummenigge	West Germany	30 December 1980	—

Year	Winner	National team	Ceremony date	Story
1979	**Kevin Keegan**	England	25 December 1979	—
1978	**Kevin Keegan**	England	27 December 1978	—
1977	**Allan Simonsen**	Denmark	27 December 1977	—
1976	**Franz Beckenbauer**	West Germany	28 December 1976	—
1975	**Oleg Blokhin**	Soviet Union	30 December 1975	—
1974	**Johan Cruyff**	Netherlands	31 December 1974	—
1973	**Johan Cruyff**	Netherlands	25 December 1973	—
1972	**Franz Beckenbauer**	West Germany	26 December 1972	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Franz Beckenbauer (West Germany) won the 1972 Ballon d'Or the same year he captained West Germany to the EURO title.
1971	**Johan Cruyff**	Netherlands	28 December 1971	—

Year	Winner	National team	Ceremony date	Story
1970	**Gerd Müller**	West Germany	29 December 1970	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Gerd Müller (West Germany) won the 1970 Ballon d'Or the same year he also won the World Cup Golden Boot, even though West Germany finished third rather than winning that tournament.
1969	**Gianni Rivera**	Italy	23 December 1969	—
1968	**George Best**	Northern Ireland	24 December 1968	—
1967	**Flórián Albert**	Hungary	26 December 1967	—
1966	**Bobby Charlton**	England	27 December 1966	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Bobby Charlton (England) won the 1966 Ballon d'Or the same year he also won the World Cup.
1965	**Eusébio**	Portugal	28 December 1965	—
1964	**Denis Law**	Scotland	22 December 1964	—
1963	**Lev Yashin**	Soviet Union	17 December 1963	—

Year	Winner	National team	Ceremony date	Story
1962	**Josef Masopust**	Czechoslovakia	18 December 1962	—
1961	**Omar Sívori**	Italy	12 December 1961	—
1960	**Luis Suárez**	Spain	13 December 1960	—
1959	**Alfredo Di Stéfano**	Spain	15 December 1959	—
1958	**Raymond Kopa**	France	16 December 1958	—
1957	**Alfredo Di Stéfano**	Spain	17 December 1957	—
1956	**Stanley Matthews**	England	18 December 1956	▶ 📖 Tap to read the story Stanley Matthews won the first-ever Ballon d'Or in 1956.

🏆 Champions by titles

Generated automatically from the edition table above. Totals group a nation with its sporting predecessor only where the source content does (Germany includes West Germany); every other name is counted as written.

Lionel Messi — **8**

2009, 2010, 2011, 2012, 2015, 2019, 2021, 2023

Cristiano Ronaldo — **5**

2008, 2013, 2014, 2016, 2017

Johan Cruyff — 3

1971, 1973, 1974

Michel Platini — 3

1983, 1984, 1985

Marco van Basten — 3

1988, 1989, 1992

Alfredo Di Stéfano — 2

1957, 1959

Franz Beckenbauer — 2

1972, 1976

Kevin Keegan — 2

1978, 1979

Karl-Heinz Rummenigge — 2

1980, 1981

Ronaldo — 2

1997, 2002

Stanley Matthews — 1

1956

Raymond Kopa 1

1958

Luis Suárez 1

1960

Omar Sívori 1

1961

Josef Masopust 1

1962

Lev Yashin 1

1963

Denis Law 1

1964

Eusébio 1

1965

Bobby Charlton 1

1966

Flórián Albert 1

1967

George Best 1

1968

Gianni Rivera 1

1969

Gerd Müller 1

1970

Oleg Blokhin 1

1975

Allan Simonsen 1

1977

Paolo Rossi 1

1982

Igor Belanov 1

1986

Ruud Gullit 1

1987

Lothar Matthäus 1

1990

Jean-Pierre Papin 1

1991

Roberto Baggio 1

1993

Hristo Stoichkov 1

1994

George Weah 1

1995

Matthias Sammer 1

1996

Zinedine Zidane 1

1998

Rivaldo 1

1999

Luís Figo 1

2000

Michael Owen 1

2001

Pavel Nedvěd 1

2003

Andriy Shevchenko 1

2004

Ronaldinho 1

2005

Fabio Cannavaro 1

2006

Kaká 1

2007

Luka Modrić 1

2018

Karim Benzema 1

2022

Rodri 1

2024

Ousmane Dembélé 1

2025

Harry Kane 1

2026

ℹ️ How it works

- The Ballon d'Or honors the best individual men's player of the year - it is not a team competition or a national-team trophy.
- A panel of football journalists, one per eligible country, ranks their top players from a shortlist, and the votes are combined into one final ranking - but the panel hasn't always been journalists alone: from 2010 to 2015, while FIFA jointly presented the award (see above), national-team captains and coaches voted alongside journalists in a combined panel of roughly 500, before it reverted to journalists only in 2016.
- The journalist panel's own size has changed too: roughly 170 countries had a vote before a 2022 reform capped it at one journalist per country from the top 100 nations in the FIFA men's world ranking, a cap still in effect for the 2025 award.
- Eligibility has widened over time: Europe-only at first, then any nationality at a European club from 1995, then fully global since 2007 (see the introduction above).
- The winner is announced at a ceremony organized by France Football magazine - held at year's end through 2021, then moved to September/October from 2022 onward (see the Ceremony date column above).

📝 Kopa Trophy winners

- France Football has presented the Kopa Trophy, a companion "best young player" award for the world's best player aged 21 or under, alongside the Ballon d'Or every year since 2018; it was not awarded in 2020, the one year the Ballon d'Or itself was cancelled.
- **2018:** Kylian Mbappé (France) - the trophy's first winner.
- **2019:** Matthijs de Ligt (Netherlands).
- **2020:** Not awarded.
- **2021:** Pedri (Spain).
- **2022:** Gavi (Spain).
- **2023:** Jude Bellingham (England).
- **2024:** Lamine Yamal (Spain).

- **2025:** Lamine Yamal (Spain) - the first player to win the Kopa Trophy twice.
- **2026:** Lamine Yamal (Spain) - his third consecutive Kopa Trophy, the first player to win it three times.

📝 Yashin Trophy winners

- France Football has also presented the Yashin Trophy, a companion "best goalkeeper" award named after Lev Yashin, alongside the Ballon d'Or every year since 2019; it was not awarded in 2020, the one year the Ballon d'Or itself was cancelled.
- **2019:** Alisson (Brazil) - the trophy's first winner.
- **2020:** Not awarded.
- **2021:** Gianluigi Donnarumma (Italy).
- **2022:** Thibaut Courtois (Belgium).
- **2023:** Emiliano Martínez (Argentina).
- **2024:** Emiliano Martínez (Argentina) - the first goalkeeper to win the Yashin Trophy in consecutive years.
- **2025:** Gianluigi Donnarumma (Italy) - his second Yashin Trophy, making him the second goalkeeper (after Martínez) to win it more than once.
- **2026:** Unai Simón (Spain).

📝 Gerd Müller Trophy winners

- France Football has also presented an award for the year's top goalscorer (club and country combined) alongside the Ballon d'Or every year since 2021; it was first awarded under the name "Striker of the Year" and renamed the Gerd Müller Trophy from 2022 onward, honoring the West Germany and Bayern Munich forward (1970 Ballon d'Or winner, see the Winners table above) after his death in August 2021 - unlike the Kopa and Yashin trophies above, it has no gap year, since it started the year after the 2020 cancellation rather than before it.
- **2021:** Robert Lewandowski (Poland) - the award's first winner, under its original name.
- **2022:** Robert Lewandowski (Poland) - the first winner under the renamed Gerd Müller Trophy, and the trophy's first repeat winner.
- **2023:** Erling Haaland (Norway).
- **2024:** Harry Kane (England) and Kylian Mbappé (France) - the trophy's first tie, both credited as joint winners on the same goal tally.

- **2025:** Viktor Gyökeres (Sweden).
- **2026:** Harry Kane (England) - his second Gerd Müller Trophy, making him the second player (after Lewandowski) to win it more than once.

📝 Johan Cruyff Trophy winners

- France Football has also presented the Johan Cruyff Trophy, a companion "best men's coach" award named after the Netherlands great (three-time Ballon d'Or winner, see the Winners table above), alongside the Ballon d'Or every year since 2024 - the newest of the three companion trophies on this page, with no gap year since it started after the Kopa/Yashin/Gerd Müller trophies had already established the pattern.
- **2024:** Carlo Ancelotti (Real Madrid) - the trophy's first winner, honored for Real Madrid's La Liga and UEFA Champions League double.
- **2025:** Luis Enrique (Paris Saint-Germain) - honored for PSG's Ligue 1, Coupe de France and first-ever UEFA Champions League title.
- **2026:** Luis de la Fuente (Spain) - honored for leading Spain to their second FIFA World Cup title (after 2010).

📝 Socrates Award winners

- France Football has also presented the Sócrates Award, a companion humanitarian award named after Brazilian great Sócrates and presented in partnership with Peace and Sport, alongside the Ballon d'Or every year since 2022 - unlike the Kopa, Yashin, Gerd Müller and Johan Cruyff trophies above, it is not restricted to men's football performance: it has gone to a female footballer and, in 2025, to a charitable foundation rather than an individual player.
- **2022:** Sadio Mané (Senegal) - the award's first winner, honored for funding a hospital, a secondary school and other infrastructure in his home village of Bambali.
- **2023:** Vinícius Júnior (Brazil) - honored for Instituto Vini Jr.'s work against racism and educational inequality in Brazil.
- **2024:** Jennifer Hermoso (Spain) - the award's first female recipient, honored for her advocacy against sexual abuse and harassment in sport.
- **2025:** Xana Foundation - founded by Johan Cruyff Trophy winner Luis Enrique (see above) and his wife Elena Cullell in memory of their daughter Xana, who died in 2019; the award's first winner that is not an individual footballer.
- **2026:** Bukayo Saka (England) - honored for his humanitarian work through the BigShoe foundation, including funding surgeries for children in Nigeria.

🎉 Memorable moments

- Stanley Matthews won the first-ever Ballon d'Or in 1956.
- Paolo Rossi became the only player in history to win the World Cup, its Golden Ball, its Golden Boot, and the Ballon d'Or all in the same year, 1982.
- Ronaldo (Brazil) won the 2002 Ballon d'Or the same year he also won the World Cup and that tournament's Golden Boot.
- Zinedine Zidane (France) won the 1998 Ballon d'Or the same year he also won the World Cup.
- Michel Platini (France) won the 1984 Ballon d'Or the same year he captained France to the EURO title and finished as the tournament's top scorer.
- Gerd Müller (West Germany) won the 1970 Ballon d'Or the same year he also won the World Cup Golden Boot, even though West Germany finished third rather than winning that tournament.
- Lothar Matthäus (West Germany) won the 1990 Ballon d'Or the same year he captained West Germany to the World Cup title.
- Fabio Cannavaro (Italy) won the 2006 Ballon d'Or the same year he captained Italy to the World Cup title.
- Ruud Gullit (Netherlands) won the 1987 Ballon d'Or the year before he captained the Netherlands to the EURO 1988 title.
- Marco van Basten (Netherlands) won the 1988 Ballon d'Or the same year he also won the EURO Golden Boot and the Netherlands won the title.
- Franz Beckenbauer (West Germany) won the 1972 Ballon d'Or the same year he captained West Germany to the EURO title.
- Bobby Charlton (England) won the 1966 Ballon d'Or the same year he also won the World Cup.
- George Weah became the first African player to win the Ballon d'Or in 1995.
- Kaká won the 2007 Ballon d'Or, the first year the award was open to players at any club worldwide, not just clubs in Europe - eligibility had already widened to any nationality in 1995.
- Lionel Messi won the first of his eight Ballon d'Or titles in 2009, more than any other player in the award's history.
- Luka Modrić became the only Croatian winner of the Ballon d'Or in 2018, the same year he also won the World Cup Golden Ball.
- The 2020 Ballon d'Or was the only edition since the award's creation in 1956 not to be presented.
- Rodri became the first defensive midfielder to win the Ballon d'Or since Lothar Matthäus in 1990, after also being named the UEFA Nations League 2023 Player of the Finals and UEFA EURO 2024 Player of the Tournament.

- Stanley Matthews remains the Ballon d'Or's oldest-ever winner, aged 41 when he claimed the inaugural award in 1956 - a record that has stood for seven decades.
- Ronaldo (Brazil) is the Ballon d'Or's youngest-ever winner, aged 21 when he won in 1997.
- Harry Kane won the 2026 Ballon d'Or, England's first winner since Michael Owen claimed the award in 2001.

📝 Notes

- Lev Yashin remains the only goalkeeper to win the men's award.
- George Weah became the first African winner in 1995.
- Luka Modrić won in 2018.
- The 2020 award was cancelled.
- Ousmane Dembélé won the 2025 award.
- Harry Kane won the 2026 award.

📚 References & review

Status: verified Last reviewed:31 October 2026

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- Marco van Basten's 1988 EURO Golden Boot/Ballon d'Or cross-reference (source 2 of 2) (https://www.uefa.com/uefaeuro/history/news/0253-0d7d771b1d5a-bab36b6c142e-1000--1988-at-a-glance/)
- Beckenbauer's 1972 Ballon d'Or (`content/ballon-dor.md`'s Winners (source 1 of 2) (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/1972_Ballon_d%27Or)
- Beckenbauer's 1972 Ballon d'Or (`content/ballon-dor.md`'s Winners (source 2 of 2) (https://de.uefa.com/uefaeuro/history/news/0253-0d7de25f77f9-952295b997f7-1000--beckenbauer-leader-of-west-germany-s-glorious-class-of-72)
- Bobby Charlton's 1966 World Cup/Ballon d'Or cross-reference (2026-10-31, (source 1 of 2) (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/1966_Ballon_d%27Or)
- Bobby Charlton's 1966 World Cup/Ballon d'Or cross-reference (2026-10-31, (source 2 of 2) (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Bobby_Charlton)

Primary sources are preferred. Historical formats and team names are recorded as used at the time; see each edition's notes for context.